

Technical Note: *Rūpa*, *Guṇa*, *Svabhāva*, and *Dharma* in a State-Dynamic Unit

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Scope: This note clarifies the four inseparable aspects attributed to every unit (*ikai*) in Madhyasth Darshan: form (*rūpa*), property or relative power (*guṇa*), essential nature (*svabhāva*), and *dharma*. Its central question is whether a unit can consistently be understood as a process or activity at the fundamental level. The same four aspects are then asked of a compound or further organisation as a containing unit, without collapsing the constituents into that whole. The process-language below is an analytical reconstruction of the primary texts, not a claim that those texts explicitly adopt a modern school of process philosophy.

1. The interpretive problem

The four terms can initially look like a list of attributes attached to an otherwise passive thing. That reading becomes difficult once the same texts describe nature as countless activities, place effort, motion, and result inseparably in every activity, and state that force belongs to state while power belongs to motion. A purely static interpretation of the unit therefore misses the texts' insistence on continuous activeness. Yet a pure process interpretation can also mislead if it dissolves the unit into events or relations, because the unit remains a definite, bounded bearer with constitution, continuity, and its own "ness."

The more adequate interpretation is that a unit is a **bounded, state-dynamic activity-whole**. "State-dynamic" preserves the inseparability of state and motion; "activity-whole" preserves the unit as an identifiable bearer rather than a passing event. The four terms then name four irreducible aspects of this one active whole, not four separable components and not four successive stages.

Every unit is a bounded, state-dynamic activity-whole. As determinate configuration it is rūpa; as power in motion and mutual influence it is guṇa; as order-specific characteristic conduct it is svabhāva; and as the innateness it bears it is dharma.

When the unit is itself a compound or a further organisation, the same four aspects apply twice: once to the constituents, once to the containing unit (§8).

2. Four questions asked of one unit

Aspect	Question answered	Primary-text emphasis	Process-compatible reading
Form (<i>rūpa</i>)	What determinate configuration is present?	Shape, volume, density, boundary-framework and reflected image	The bounded configuration to which result is connected; not an effect in the same sense as <i>guṇa</i>
Property (<i>guṇa</i>)	How does the unit's power operate?	Relative power; generative, degenerative, or mediative motion and effect in mutuality	The unit's operative power in motion and its definite influence when units come together
Essential nature (<i>svabhāva</i>)	What characteristic conduct or functional significance does that operation express?	Essentiality; usefulness of properties; conduct through which essentiality is expressed	The recurring, order-specific functional character displayed through the unit's powers
<i>Dharma</i>	What innateness does the unit bear according to its order?	<i>Dhāraṇā</i> or innateness; existence, growth, hope to live, and happiness, cumulatively across the four orders	The order-specific innateness borne on the effort/force side; in the knowledge order its evidence and evaluation is happiness and resolution

The table is analytical rather than sequential. A unit does not first acquire form, then activate property, then develop essential nature, and finally reach *dharma*. The four are simultaneous aspects of the same unit. Nor does “fundamental aspect” mean ontological independence: *svabhāva* depends on powers for its expression, but it cannot be reduced to a list of powers; *dharma* is evidenced through conduct, but it cannot be reduced to one episode of conduct.

3. The process basis: state, motion, and result

Madhyasth Darshan treats the unit as both a state and a motion. Force (*bal*) is identified on the side of state, power (*śakti*) on the side of motion, while state and motion remain inseparable. Every activity is correspondingly presented as the inseparable presence of effort, motion, and result (*śram–gati–pariṇām*). These are not three chronological moments. Effort names the active tendency already present, motion its dynamic expression, and result the determinate condition being attained or maintained (SB, pp. 58–62, 248–252).

One passage relates this triad directly to the four aspects: effort or force is present as *dharma* and *svabhāva*; motion as *svabhāva* and *guṇa*; and result as *rūpa* and immortality (*amaratva*). This does not establish a one-to-one derivation, because *svabhāva* crosses both effort and motion. It does, however, make a static bundle-of-properties reading implausible. Form is connected to determinate result, property to motion, essential nature to the characteristic continuity of effort in motion, and *dharma* to

the innateness borne as force or effort. Immortality of result is the goal of constitutional completeness for the sentient atom; it is not a claim that every present shape is indestructible (SB, pp. 60–62).

The resulting process-picture is therefore:

Activity-side	Ontological expression
Effort or force	Present as <i>dharma</i> and <i>svabhāva</i> : the innateness borne, and the essential nature through which force appears as conduct
Motion or power	Present as <i>svabhāva</i> and <i>guṇa</i> : the operative influence of power, characterised as essential nature
Result	Present as <i>rūpa</i> and immortality (<i>amaratva</i>): determinate configuration, oriented toward non-decomposable result at constitutional completeness

4. Why *rūpa* is not an absolute effect

Form and property must not be separated as “absolute effect” and “relative effect.” *Rūpa* is not an effect in the same sense as *guṇa*. It is the real configuration by which the unit is bounded and individuated: shape, volume, and density. Its motion-path and constitution provide a framework within which the unit remains one definite unit. A developing atom can change in form as its constitution changes, so form is neither an immaterial essence nor an eternally immutable shape (MVD, pp. 42, 50–51; SB, pp. 55, 249–250).

Form is nevertheless relationally encountered. In mutual facing, the unit’s form is reflected or imaged to another unit, and its dimensions are measured only in comparison with another measure. Reflection does not create the form; it is the manner in which an already bounded unit becomes present across mutuality. The distinction is consequently between **unit-grounded configuration** and **relationally operative power**, not between absolute and relative effects.

The word “absolute” is especially unsuitable here because the texts reserve absolute truth for coexistence as nature saturated in *satta*. Form, properties, essential nature, and *dharma* together belong to the objective truth of units. A useful formulation is therefore:

Rūpa is objectively unit-grounded but relationally encountered; guṇa is unit-grounded as power and relationally actualised as effect.

5. *Guṇa*: relative power rather than a static quality

The primary definition calls *guṇa* relative power (*sāpekṣa śakti*) and also the effect that arises when more than one entity comes together. A later analysis identifies the force-bearing unit as *guṇī* and its power as *guṇa*: the bearer and the property are inseparable, while the property’s operation is evident as motion, influence, and field of influence (MVD, p. 47; SB, pp. 248–252, 256–257). That meeting of

entities is still a relative-power fact. It is not, by itself, the appearance of a new bounded unit. Mixture and compound are distinguished in §8.

The three modes specify the direction of that operation:

Mode of <i>guṇa</i>	Definition	Direction of effect
<i>Sam</i>	Power assisting <i>srjan</i>	Generative, formative, or developmental
<i>Viṣam</i>	Power assisting <i>visarjan</i>	Degenerative, dissolutive, or declining
<i>Madhyastha</i>	Power assisting <i>vibhava</i>	Mediative, sustaining, balancing, and conserving

“Regenerative” is narrower than *sam*, because *srjan* need not restore a former state; “generative” is the safer general rendering. *Viṣam* is dissolutive rather than generative. *Madhyastha* does not mean inactivity or an average between two extremes. It names active regulation by which generative and degenerative movements remain balanced and a definite organisation is sustained (MVD, pp. 26, 50–51).

These modes are not moral categories. Formation and dissolution both participate in material and biological cycles. The triad names the directional character of power before any specifically biological, animal, or human evaluation of that power has been made.

6. *Svabhāva*: essentiality and the usefulness of properties

The primary text places two definitions together: essentiality or fundamental character (*maulikata*) is *svabhāva*, and the usefulness (*upayogitā*) of properties is *svabhāva* (MVD, p. 47). “Usefulness” cannot mean merely beneficial, agreeable, or useful to a human observer, because the same text includes devitalising and cruel essential natures. The term is better read here as **functional significance, operative relevance, or the kind of conduct in which the unit’s powers become meaningful within an order**.

This explains why *svabhāva* is not merely another classification of *guṇa*. The generic classification of property remains *sam–viṣam–madhyastha* across all four orders, whereas the classification of essential nature changes with the order:

Order	Generic power-modes (<i>guṇa</i>)	Order-specific essential nature (<i>svabhāva</i>)
Material	Generative, degenerative, mediative	Integration–disintegration and their continuity
Biological or pranic	Generative, degenerative, mediative	Vitalising–devitalising
Animal	Generative, degenerative, mediative	Cruel–uncruel

Order	Generic power-modes (<i>guṇa</i>)	Order-specific essential nature (<i>svabhāva</i>)
Knowledge or human	Generative, degenerative, mediative	Fortitude, courage, generosity, kindness, grace, and compassion

The knowledge-order cell records that order's defining essential nature, not a paired opposite-set of the kind *cruel–uncruel* is for the animal order. Unawakened human essential nature is named separately as servility, perfidy, and cruelty (MVD, p. 58). In the progression of awakening it appears as that inhumane triad before awakening, as fortitude, courage, and generosity with awakening, and as kindness, grace, and compassion in the completeness of awakening (SB, p. 180). Those are states of the human unit, not a second definition of knowledge-order *svabhāva*.

At the material level the distinction between *guṇa* and *svabhāva* is thin: generative–degenerative motion and integration–disintegration conduct closely track one another. It becomes clearer in the higher orders. Generative activity alone does not tell whether a biological composition nourishes or debilitates a body, whether animal conduct causes or avoids suffering, or whether a human unit is in the inhumane or the awakened appearance of essential nature. Those are further, order-specific determinations of what the powers amount to in conduct.

The texts therefore describe conduct as the activity through which essentiality is expressed and identify conduct itself with *svabhāva* (MVD, p. 77). Essential nature is unit-grounded as fundamental character but relation-disclosed in its expression. Recognition does not create it. A plant's vitalising or devitalising character, an animal's friendliness or opposition, and a human's generosity or cruelty become evident only in definite mutualities, yet they are not arbitrary projections by an observer.

7. *Dharma*: the innateness borne by an order

The primary definition, *dhāraṇā hi dharma*, presents *dharma* as what is innately borne or maintained. In this technical use it does not initially mean religious affiliation, a statutory command, or an externally imposed moral duty. It names the order-specific innateness of the unit, mapped on the effort/force side of the triad rather than as a later effect of *guṇa* (MVD, p. 47; SB, pp. 60–61).

The texts state the order-specific *dharma*s cumulatively:

Order	<i>Dharma</i>
Material	Existence
Biological or pranic	Existence and growth
Animal	Existence, growth, and hope to live
Knowledge or human	Existence, growth, hope to live, and happiness

The higher order does not lose the *dharma* of the lower. A biological unit remains existent while evidencing growth; an animal joint form evidences both and additionally the hope to live; the knowledge order bears the further possibility and requirement of happiness. The order-table must be read with the body/*jeevan* split: existence and growth are evident in the body, whereas hope to live is observed only in *jeevan*; existence and growth are evident in the human body, while *sanskar* and happiness must be realised in *jeevan* for that *dharma* to be meaningful (SB, pp. 179–180; MVD, pp. 50–51, 115). The table does not imply that every composite organisation is indestructible. Existence belongs to the realities participating in composition, while particular compositions can form and disintegrate. How the four aspects then sit on both the constituents and the containing unit is taken up in §8.

Dharma is therefore not simply the long-term effect of *guṇa*, nor a synonym for whatever continuity a present form happens to maintain. It names what the unit innately bears. Conduct can accord with that innateness or fail it. In the knowledge order the further *dharma* is happiness, and its evaluation in mutuality is resolution. Fulfilment in that human sense is the evidence of innateness, not a second generic definition of *dharma*.

8. Compound, mixture, and a containing unit's four aspects

The four aspects were stated for a generic unit. Composition raises a further question: when several units come together, does one tetrad cover both the parts and the whole, or must the same four questions be asked twice?

Mixture (*mishran*) and compound (*yaugik*) are distinguished by conduct, not by mere proximity. In a mixture the participating units keep their respective conducts. In a compound they combine in definite proportion, give up exhibiting those respective conducts as the public motion of the whole, and exhibit a new kind of conduct (MVD, p. 42). That new conduct is the containing unit's own form, property, essential nature, and *dharma*. The constituents nevertheless remain of their order: whatever a thing is constituted of, it remains equal to that basic entity; soil in a pot stays soil, and pranic cells in a body stay of the pranic order (SB, p. 260). Composition is not development: a new compound may close a new bounded conduct while the atomic progression toward constitutional completeness remains a distinct line (SB, pp. 75–76).

The reconstruction therefore assigns **two tetrads**, not one fused list. The texts state the new-versus-retained conduct distinction and the order-of-constituent claim; they do not write “two tetrads.” The two-tetrad assignment is this note's way of keeping those two facts together.

Aspect	Constituents	Containing compound as a unit
Form (<i>rūpa</i>)	Own shape, volume, density, and boundary	New bounded configuration of the whole
Property (<i>guṇa</i>)	Relative powers continue under the organisation	Public effect of the whole as one relative power, not a sum of the constituents' effects

Aspect	Constituents	Containing compound as a unit
Essential nature (<i>svabhāva</i>)	Order-specific conduct of each part remains	The compound's own essentiality as that new conduct
<i>Dharma</i>	Existence, and the innateness of each constituent's own order	The compound's own innateness as that organisation; disintegration ends the organisation, not the existence of the constituents

A mixture has no such containing unit. Results can still flow: collision and mixture can produce mutual *guṇa*-effect without a new bearer. The definition of *guṇa* as the effect that arises when more than one entity comes together (§5) therefore covers interaction as such; it does not by itself decide whether a new unit has appeared.

The same two-tetrad pattern continues where organisation is biological rather than physicochemical. A cell and a body are further containing units: each has its own bounded form, public relative power, order-specific conduct, and innateness, while the cells of a body remain of the pranic order. Those organisations are not themselves *yaugik* in the atomic or molecular sense. Sentience of an animal or human joint form belongs to the *jeevan* joined with the body, not to the composition of cells. Composing *jeevan* yields an organised assembly of *jeevan*, never a larger *jeevan*. Human families and social assemblies are not compounds in the physicochemical sense; their continuity is achieved through relationship-fulfilment rather than chemically definite proportion (*The Ontology of Coexistence*, §1.10; *A State-Dynamic Model of Coexistence*, §5.4).

9. Human relationships: where usefulness becomes explicitly normative

In human relationships, understanding adds a normative dimension that is not present in the same way in material mutuality. Understanding the relationship reveals its inherent value; the value makes appropriate conduct recognisable; humane *svabhāva* enables that value to be expressed; and fulfilment contributes to resolution and happiness. An action may be effective as *guṇa* while expressing an inhumane *svabhāva* and failing to evidence human *dharma*. Manipulation can successfully influence another person, but causal effectiveness does not make the conduct just or mutually fulfilling.

It is consequently too narrow to define *svabhāva* universally as “what sustains a relationship.” Sustaining and balancing belong most directly to the mediative mode of *guṇa*, while human relationship-fulfilment additionally requires recognition of values, justice, and appropriate conduct. The human sequence can be stated as:

understanding of relationship → recognition of value → conduct expressing *svabhāva* → fulfilment evidencing human *dharma* as resolution and happiness

This is a knowledge-order articulation of how innateness becomes evident in relationship. It does not replace *dhāraṇā* as the generic definition, and it does not apply as a substitute definition in material,

biological, or animal nature.

10. Limits of the process interpretation

A process-oriented reading is consistent with the primary texts under five constraints.

First, “process” must mean persistent organised activity, not a momentary event. Units retain definite boundaries, constitutions, and identifiable continuity while remaining active.

Second, the four aspects must not be treated as chronological stages. Effort, motion, and result are inseparable in every activity; correspondingly, *rūpa*, *guṇa*, *svabhāva*, and *dharma* are co-present aspects of the unit.

Third, relational manifestation must not be confused with observer-construction. Form is reflected, property exerts influence, essential nature is recognised, and *dharma* is evidenced — and in the knowledge order evaluated as resolution — in mutuality; none is invented by the observer.

Fourth, the unit must not be reduced to its current relations. Madhyasth Darshan is process-compatible but not relation-only. The bearer (*guṇī*), its boundary, its constitution, its “ness,” and its order-specific *dharma* remain real. “Activity-whole” is therefore more faithful than saying that the unit is nothing but a process.

Fifth, the four aspects of a containing unit must not be treated as a sum or replacement of the constituents’ four aspects. Mixture retains the participants’ conducts and supplies no further tetrad; compound, cell, and body each add a containing tetrad while the constituents remain of their order (§8).

11. Compact formulation

Rūpa is how the unit is configured and bounded: shape, volume, and density.

Guṇa is how its power operates and affects mutuality.

Svabhāva is what characteristic, order-specific conduct that operation expresses.

Dharma is the innateness the unit bears (dhāraṇā); in the knowledge order this is evidenced as happiness and evaluated as resolution.

The four can be compressed into one sentence without collapsing their differences:

A unit is a bounded activity-whole whose configuration is rūpa, whose relative causal efficacy is guṇa, whose characteristic functional conduct is svabhāva, and whose order-specific innateness is dharma.

When the unit is a compound or a further organisation, that sentence applies twice: to each constituent, and to the containing unit as a further bounded activity-whole.

References

Madhyasth Darshan primary texts

- **MVD** — Nagraj, A. [*Madhyasth Darshan — Co-existentialism*](#). English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: definitions of the four aspects (p. 47); form and the *sam-viṣam-madhyastha* distinction (pp. 50–51); order-specific *svabhāva* and *dharma* (pp. 50–51, 115); mediative regulation (p. 26); atomic constitution, mixture (*mishran*), and compound (*yaugik*) (p. 42); inhumane essential nature (p. 58); conduct as expression of essentiality (p. 77).
- **SB** — Nagraj, A. [*Samadhanatmak Bhautikvad \(Resolution Centred Materialism\)*](#). English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: effort–motion–result and state–motion (pp. 58–62); change of form and properties with development (p. 55); composition is not development (pp. 75–76); order-specific *dharma* and the body/*jeevan* split (pp. 179–180); force, power, form, reflection, influence, recognition, and evaluation (pp. 248–252); bearer and property (pp. 256–257); a composition remains of the order of its constituents (p. 260).
- **JV** — Nagraj, A. [*Jeevan Vidya: An Introduction*](#). English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Consulted for the peepal-tree illustration of form, properties, essential nature, and *dharma* (p. 113).

Related studies

- [*The Ontology of Coexistence*](#), especially §1.3, “The unit and its four aspects in mutuality,” and §1.10, “Composition and assemblies.”
- [*A State-Dynamic Model of Coexistence*](#), especially §5.4, “The tetrad of a containing unit.”